

Build Your Academic Website in 15 Minutes: A startup guide for graduate students and senior researchers.

This guide will walk you through the process of building a full academic website with AI, hosted for free. If you have an existing site, its contents can be migrated. No coding is required.

Three things you'll need:

Cursor: download it free at cursor.com. During setup, create an account and pick a plan that includes Claude (Pro or above).

A GitHub account: sign up at github.com if you don't have one.

Fill out the prompt document: open the file called `GRAD_STUDENT_SITE_PROMPT.md` if you are a grad student or `ACADEMIC_SITE_PROMPT.md` if you are further along in your career. You have two options:

Migrating an existing site: Just paste the URL of your current website. Claude will pull the content from it.

Building from scratch: Fill in the "Who I Am" section with your information, publications, software, etc. Attach your CV PDF, headshot, and any paper PDFs you want hosted.

Steps

1. Create a GitHub repository.

Go to github.com, click the + icon in the top right, select "New repository." Name it something like `yourname-site` or `yourusername.github.io`. Set it to Public. Don't add any files — leave it empty.

2. Open Cursor and start a conversation with Claude.

Open Cursor. Press `Cmd+I` (Mac) or `Ctrl+I` (Windows) to open the chat.

3. Give Claude your completed prompt.

Attach your filled-out your chosen prompt document (plus any PDFs/photos) and say:

"Create a new academic website for [Your Name], using the website building instructions attached. The GitHub repository I'd like to use is at

`https://github.com/YOURUSERNAME/REPONAME`. Install Hugo so that we can do local builds. Build locally first and give me a localhost link so I can preview.”

If migrating, say instead:

“Create a new academic website for [Your Name] by migrating content from [your existing site URL], using the website building instructions attached. My GitHub repository is at [repo URL]. Build locally first so I can preview.”

Claude will scaffold the site. This may take a few minutes for large sites.

4. Preview and approve.

Claude will give you a link like `localhost:1313`. Click it to browse your site. Tell Claude what to fix — layout, missing content, ordering, anything. Iterate until you’re satisfied. You can speak to Claude like you would a person who is designing your site.

5. Push it live.

When ready:

“Looks good. Commit and push to main.”

Your site will be live within a few minutes. If you’re using a custom domain (e.g., `yourname.harvard.edu`), tell Claude: “Set up a custom domain pointing to [your domain]” and follow your university’s DNS instructions.

After It’s Live

Open Cursor anytime to make updates. Here are common prompts:

Add a journal article:

“Add a new journal article to my site: - Title: [title] - Authors: [comma-separated names] - Publication venue: [e.g., “American Political Science Review, 111, 3, Pp. 484–501”] - Year: [year] - Abstract: [paste abstract] - DOI or URL: [link] - Topic: [one of your research areas]

The article PDF is attached. Build locally first.”

Add a custom short URL:

“Add a new short URL redirect: - Short path: /myproject (this becomes yoursite.com/myproject)
- Destination: [full URL or site path]

Push when done.”

Update a person’s profile (for group sites):

“Update [Name]’s profile: change their title to [new title] and replace their photo with the attached image. Push when done.”

Add a new research area:

“Add a new research area called ‘[Name]’ with this description: [1-2 sentences]. Assign these existing publications to it: [list titles]. Push when done.”

Add a presentation or talk:

“Add a new talk: - Title: [title] - Event: [conference/venue name] - Date: [date] - Slides PDF attached. Push when done.”

If multiple people are editing the site:

Before starting work, tell Claude: “Pull any recent changes to main first.” This prevents conflicts with others’ edits.

If Something Goes Wrong

Site isn’t updating after a push: Go to your repository on GitHub, click the “Actions” tab. If there’s a red X, copy the error and tell Claude: “The build failed. Here’s the error: [paste].”

You don’t like a recent change: Tell Claude: “Revert the last commit and push.” Everything is versioned, so nothing is lost forever.